

Haiti



Formerly a French colony, Haiti shares the Caribbean island of Hispaniola with the Dominican Republic. At independence in 1804, it became the world's first black republic.



GEOGRAPHY

Predominantly mountainous, with forests and fertile plains.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with rain throughout the year. Humid in coastal areas, much cooler in the mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Haitians are of African descent. A few have European roots, primarily French. The rigid class structure maintains vast disparities of wealth. The majority of the population live in extreme poverty; Haiti is one of the poorest countries in the Americas. A combination of political oppression and a collapsing economy led thousands to seek asylum in the US or the Dominican Republic. Though most are Christians, many Haitians practice Voodoo, which was recognized as an official religion in 2003.



THE ECONOMY

In crisis due to instability, hurricane damage, and corruption. Profiteering from narcotics trade to US. Food shortages. 70% unemployment.



INSIGHT: A slave rebellion headed by Toussaint Louverture in 1791 led to Haiti's independence



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Haiti

DATE OF FORMATION: 1804

CAPITAL: Port-au-Prince

POPULATION: 10 million

TOTAL AREA: 10,714 sq. miles
(27,750 sq. km)

DENSITY: 943 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: French Creole*, French

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 80%, Protestant 16%, other 3%, nonreligious 1%; Voodoo is widely practiced

ETHNIC MIX: Black African 95%, Mixed race and European 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Gourde = 100 centimes